



R. V. MOORTHY

kilograms in a match, with some even falling ill.

India looked weary in its first two afternoon games against China and Japan. Composure was missing in both circles, and narrow one-goal wins came only through Harmanpreet Singh's drag-flicking brilliance. Opponents' low defensive blocks caused headaches, and India was vulnerable to counterattacks.

The breakthrough came in the third game against Kazakhstan.

India's 15-0 rout saw the entire team egging on Dilpreet Singh to score, which he eventually did. That moment proved symbolic: in the final, it was Dilpreet's brace that sealed India's fourth Asia Cup.

New faces, new roles

The tournament became a coming-of-age platform for several players. Rajinder Singh, Shilanand Lakra, Vivek Sagar Prasad, and Suraj Karkera showed they were ready to take the baton in this new Olympic

cycle, especially with Hockey India already talking of rebuilding the squad.

Meanwhile, skipper Harmanpreet stepped into a reinvented role. Usually the defensive anchor, the 29-year-old, still working back to full fitness after injuries, adopted a quarterback-like presence, launching 60-yard aerial passes to open new attacking avenues. Though not at his sharpest from short corners late in the tournament, he remained India's